

The representation of immigration and gender in *Princesas*

The Digital Encyclopedia of European History affirms that prostitution (commonly known as *the world's oldest profession*) has increased since the urbanization and transport revolution in the nineteenth century, which led to a massive circulation of immigrant sex workers around Europe (EHNE, n.d.). In 2023 alone, in Spain, this industry moved around 4 billion euros according to the National Institute of Statistics. However, there are no specific laws regarding prostitution in Spain (El Confidencial, 2023). Sex work was decriminalised in 1995, to allow individuals in this field of work to contact the police when faced with a dangerous situation (Instituto de la Mujer, 2011, p. 25). As a result, sex work has become more normalized in Spain and had gradually entered the public discourse (Instituto de la Mujer, 2011, p. 26).

Princesas, a short drama film released in 2005, follows the life of Caye, a Hispanic woman saving money for breast implants, and Zulema, an undocumented immigrant from the Dominican Republic. Both meet working as sex workers in Madrid, and soon become friends. The following essay discusses the representation of gender and immigration in the movie directed by Fernando León de Aranoa. It aims to analyse the intersectionality between gender and immigration, examine forms of structural violence (such as scarcity and racism), contrast theoretical approaches to sex work, reflect on the female body's role in the film and empowerment through friendship.

To begin, it is necessary to define key concepts, such as sex work, which will be understood, as with all other terms, according to United Nations (UN) guidelines as a consensual economic activity (UNAIDS, 2012, p. 4). Furthermore, gender violence (unequal power relations) and economic precariousness (lack of social protection) will be understood as a form of discrimination that affects migrant women who are typically exposed to racism (exclusion of a person based on their race) and xenophobia (rejection of foreigners). Additionally, it is important to keep in mind that sexual orientalism, which refers to the fetishization of racialized bodies, will also be examined (Yeğenoğlu, 1998, p. 101).

The commodification of femininity in the context of sex work

One of the most important conversations in the film relies on femininity as a commodity tied to socio-economic survival. In the 1970s, socialist feminism argued that capitalism creates a system in which belonging means performing valuable and productive activities in exchange for money or social status (Federici, 2004, p. 13). As Zillah Eisenstein (*Capitalist Patriarchy and the Case for Socialist Feminism*, 1979, p.5) explains, discussing the Western world, the lack of opportunities for women, mixed with the patriarchal view of sex and gender, opened up the possibility of earning economic stability through sex work.

During the late 1980s, the commodification of the female body was defended by a group of sex workers in the book *Sex Work: Writings by Women in the Sex Industry*, where various contributors argue that sex work can be a form of labor that is freely chosen and empowering, enabling individuals to take control over their bodies and lives (Delacoste and Alexander, 1987). However, not everybody agreed with this statement, such as the political sciences professor Sheila Jeffreys, who portrayed her opinion in *The Idea of Prostitution*: "Prostitution is not simply a job. It represents one of the most extreme forms of women's sexual

exploitation and a fundamental institution in the subordination of women in all societies where it exists" (Jeffreys, 1997, p. 3).

Jeffreys' point of view aligns with the core message of *Princesas*. Caye, the main character, constantly compares her body to other females, which prompts her to save money for breast implants. After meeting Zulema, Caye also starts braiding her hair as it helps her to "conseguir más trabajo" (*Princesas*, 2005, 00:35:20). This phrase indicates the complete transformation of the body into a marketable asset, whilst reinforcing the perception of Latina women as sexually appealing. Zulema appears to internalise this appeal and use it to her advantage. "Les digo de todo. Cosas socias. Llénamelo de leche. No sé por qué, pero les encanta" (León de Aranoa, 2005, 00:41:00).

Whilst Jeffrey strongly critiques sex work as an industry that facilitates male violence and exploitation, other scholars, particularly from postfeminist and queer perspectives, argue that sex work can act as a source of agency, empowerment, and resistance (Grant, 2014, p. 7). Amelia Jones argues that agency in the body is not necessarily lost by its objectification and that women can reclaim power by controlling how their bodies are represented and consumed (Jones, 2006, p. 18).

Moreover, Caye's choice to modify her body (by saving up for breast implants and braiding her hair) could be interpreted not only as internalised oppression but also as a form of active self-preservation to survive economically or even to gain control over how she is perceived and valued in a hyper-capitalist, patriarchal context. This contradicts Jeffrey's deterministic view by suggesting that not all acts within patriarchal systems are passive reproductions of it, some are strategic negotiations for survival, dignity, or control. Based on this notion, Caye's body modifications may be reinterpreted as conscious adaptations, rather than purely evidence of victimhood.

In *Princesas*, femininity functions as a tool of capitalist exchange, underlining the competition between women for economic survival. Caye desires breast implants and adapts braided hairstyles to attract clients, reflecting how physical appearance calculates strategy in the sexual economy. The "kingdom" of sex workers with migrant women "competing for the crown of male attraction and money" (Penny, 2011, p. 45), offers a dark metaphor for the neoliberal market-consumption of female bodies. In this context, *Princesas* may be considered a modern fairytale; femininity becomes a battlefield in which people both survive and suffer.

Intersecting racism, xenophobia, and gendered oppression

The above recalls another visible issue addressed in the film: gendered oppression is not experienced uniformly. Kimberlé Crenshaw, an American law professor, coined the term "intersectional feminism" in 1989, a new wave of the movement that aims to represent how various forms of inequality often operate together and exacerbate each other (Crenshaw, 1989). From Crenshaw's point of view, all inequality is not created equal.

"We tend to talk about race inequality as separate from inequality based on gender, class, sexuality, or immigrant status. What's often missing is how some people are subject to all of these, and the experience is not just the sum of its parts. Intersectional feminism centers the voices of those experiencing overlapping, concurrent forms of oppression to understand the depths of the inequalities and the relationships among them in any given context" (Crenshaw, 1989, p. 140).

Regarding this issue, the Director of *Princesas*, Fernando León de Aranoa, said: "I wanted to talk about immigration, not from statistics, but from emotion" (El País, 2005). Aranoa aimed to humanize migrants, moving beyond political discourse. His effort appears clear from

certain quotes within the movie, for instance, during the conversations between Spanish sex workers about migrants: “Nos están robando el trabajo, lo hacen más barato” (*Princesas*, León de Aranoa, 2005, [00:37:12]). The storyline can be seen as a form of cinematic resistance through social realism, where there are no heroes or villains, just a portrait of marginalized women. However, a study carried out by Gemma Teixidó Farré, Pilar Medina Bravo, and Miquel Rodrigo Alsina ("*The gender perspective in the study of the representation of immigration in contemporary Spanish cinema: The case of Princesas*"), pointed out that although *Princesas* aims to dignify the immigrant woman, it still relies on certain stereotypes in its portrayal. This suggests a tension between the director's intentions and conventional narratives that may continue to perpetuate simplified images of female immigration. "Among the results obtained, a stereotyped visualization of the immigrant woman is confirmed, which contrasts with the dignification of 'otherness' that the film seeks to promote" (Teixidó Farré, Medina Bravo and Rodrigo Alsina, 2014, p. 85). An example of this is Zulema, the Dominican character, who is primarily represented through her suffering; she is undocumented, in an economically precarious situation, sexually assaulted, and ultimately deported. Whilst this portrayal generates empathy, it also risks reducing her identity to a passive victim who lacks agency. Zulema is seen as helpless and dependent on the native protagonist (Caye) for protection or salvation.

Paul Julian Smith, a cinema theorist, highlights in his work *Spanish Practices: Literature, Cinema, Television* (2008) how immigrants are portrayed as peripheral yet essential to understanding modern Spain. Smith argues that Spanish filmmakers often position immigrant characters at the margins of narratives, reflecting their societal (Smith, 2008, p. 75). However, these characters are crucial for exploring themes of national identity and social change. By focusing on their experiences, filmmakers shed light on the complexities of Spain's multicultural reality. Smith asserts that this narrative strategy not only mirrors the

immigrant's real-life but also challenges audiences to reconsider the notion of Spanish identity in an increasingly diverse society.

The emphasis on structural racism and xenophobia in sex work in the film are a direct reference to the common mentality in Spain in the early 2000s, as visible in the "*Evolution of racism and xenophobia in Spain*" report published by the Hispanic Ministry of Labor and Social Economy:

"Expressions like 'They're taking our jobs,' 'They're working for less money,' or 'They're taking a position I cannot get because they're working for less money' are common when talking about immigration. This is especially true when the person speaking finds themselves competing with the immigrant population for the same jobs, without deteriorating working conditions" (Ministry of Labor and Social Economy, 2009, p. 47).

The film reflects what anthropologist María Dolores Vargas Llovera defines as Spain's "second attitude" towards immigration; Zulema's body, marked as hypersexual as well as racialized, is commodified and rejected since foreigners are perceived as "the other". A form of racialized orientalism prejudice is depicted via the scene where a Spanish woman claims on TV that Latinas "smell bad because of their hormones" (*Princesas*, 2005, 00:55:20). Zulema is made exotic, and she reproduces the colonial sexual fantasy instead of escaping from it with her internalized belief in her "superior sexual status".

In the film, the arrival of foreign labour generates fear among the native population of being replaced because the former's urgency for work drives them to accept wage cuts and other precarious working conditions. This fear tends to increase in the face of a possible change in the economic cycle, as observed in the qualitative research conducted in late 2006 and early

2007, corresponding to the MEXEES project, as seen in interview excerpts (Cea D'Ancona and Valles, 2009).

As Gabrielle Carty also (2009, p.130) argues, Zulema's character is "doubly displaced," both geographically and socially, revealing how *Princesas* denounces the invisibilization of immigrant women within Spanish society, which leads to another important topic: female friendships can serve as a counterforce to systemic oppression.

Female friendship as resistance against marginalization

Zulema: "Tú tienes un país, yo no tengo nada" .

Caye: "Me gusta como eres, Zule" (Princesas, 2005, 01:13:10).

These lines reflect how the bond between the two protagonists, one Spanish, and one a Dominican immigrant, becomes a space of mutual care and emotional resistance to social exclusion and sexism. The feminist activist bell hooks (intentionally uses lowercase letters in her name to emphasize the importance of her ideas rather than her identity) argues that the conventional understanding of femininity, shaped by male perspectives, is inherently sexist and ingrained in women's lives. Additionally, women often adhere to societal norms that have socialized them to internalize harmful, competitive behaviors rooted in male supremacy. This internalization can lead to women competing against each other, perpetuating patriarchal systems. Consequently, she proposes that genuine sisterhood necessitates confronting differences and forging bonds based on a shared commitment to feminist action (hooks, 2000, p. 54).

Also, Prádanos (2012) highlights how *Princesas* builds "a relational cultural identity," positioning the friendship between Caye and Zulema as a site of resistance that challenges

nationalistic exclusions and gendered hierarchies. "The film moves beyond the binary of native versus foreigner by constructing a relational identity, where emotional bonds between women transcend national and cultural borders" (Prádanos, 2012, p.37).

Despite their different social positions, Caye and Zulema share a bond that transcends prejudice and borders. The gesture of braiding Zulema's hair shifts from a commercial strategy to an act of intimacy (*Princesas*, 2005, 00:45:30). The braid, initially labelled as "unhygienic," becomes a symbol of reconciliation. Their shared loneliness unites them, offering a form of resistance not through political discourse, but through emotional proximity.

The notion of sisterhood as resistance has been further explored by contemporary feminist scholars like Lidia Rodak (2020), who examines how women's circles and communities function as mechanisms of support and empowerment in her article "*Sisterhood and the 4th wave of feminism: An analysis of circles of women in Poland*", Rodak argues that these intimate spaces allow women to negotiate their social position collectively and create alternative networks of belonging (2020). This perspective adds another dimension to understanding the relationship between Caye and Zulema. Their friendship becomes not just personal support but potentially a microcosm of political resistance through care and solidarity.

Within the film, this sisterhood manifests in several key scenes. When Zulema falls ill, Caye brings her medicine and food, crossing social boundaries to provide care. When Caye decides to reveal her profession to her date, Zulema offers emotional support that overlooks their competitive professional relationship (*Princesas*, 2005, 01:15:05). These moments of mutual vulnerability challenge the individualistic, competitive ethos of neoliberal capitalism that pits women against each other, especially in the sexual economy. Their friendship represents what

feminist scholar Sara Ahmed (2017) might call "willful subjects", individuals who refuse to comply with normative expectations about who they should associate with and care for.

The female body as a site of structural and symbolic violence

The film also explores the female body as a site of control. "Ya no puedo con este país" (*Princesas*, 2005, 01:10:45). The violence Zulema suffers is not only physical, but systemic; she is criminalized, dehumanized, and manipulated by a policeman who promised her documents (visa). While Caye is forced to perform oral sex in the bathroom of a restaurant (*Princesas*, 2005, 00:48:10).

Judith Butler in *Gender Trouble* says that the body is a site of political struggle: "If sexuality is culturally constructed within existing power relations, then the postulation of a normative sexuality that is 'before,' 'outside,' or 'beyond' power is a cultural impossibility" (Butler, 1990, p.40). This theoretical insight is essential for understanding *Princesas*, where the sexuality of the main characters, though shaped by patriarchal norms, is not reducible to them. Caye and Zulema may operate within a structure of male dominance through their involvement in sex work, but the film also shows moments of agency and intimacy that challenge simplistic narratives of victimhood. In Butler's terms, they embody a "repetition of the law which is not its consolidation, but its displacement," revealing how female sexuality, even under constraint, can carry subversive potential (Butler, 1990, p. 42).

While Judith Butler argues that repetition within normative structures can create subversive spaces, Catharine MacKinnon, a radical feminist legal scholar, critiques this optimism. In *Toward a Feminist Theory of the State* (1989), she emphasizes that female sexuality is constructed under male dominance and that the idea of agency or subversion within that

framework is often an illusion. "Sexuality is to feminism what work is to Marxism: that which is most one's own, yet most taken away" (MacKinnon, 1989, p.3).

Applying this to *Princesas*, MacKinnon might argue that Zulema's or Caye's moments of "intimacy" or "control" are ultimately circumscribed by the systemic nature of gendered violence. The sexual assaults and coerced acts the women experience are not deviations, they are the norm in a world where the female body is available to men's needs, particularly when that body is racialized or undocumented. For MacKinnon, there is no "outside" from which to subvert if one's entire sexual identity is formed within coercive structures.

From a more psychoanalytic and affect-based approach, Lauren Berlant might challenge the idea that repetition is subversive at all. Instead, she emphasizes how individuals become attached to fantasies that injure them, because those fantasies sustain a sense of possibility, even within conditions of oppression. Zulema's desire to get her documents or to be accepted, even as she experiences systemic violence, could be read as what Berlant calls a "cruel optimism," in which hope persists precisely because its failure is unbearable to accept. "A relation of cruel optimism exists when something you desire is an obstacle to your flourishing" (Berlant, 2011, p.1). This framework suggests that the small moments of tenderness or hope in *Princesas* are not necessarily liberatory, they are survival strategies entangled with structures that continue to harm.

The violence perpetrated by the protagonists has a symbolic aspect. Fernando León de Aranoa refers to the protagonists as "invisible women" to describe women who are not heard, and whose words are spoken by others. (León de Aranoa, 2005a: 139). This silence is central to Zulema's experience with sexual abuse, in a key scene in which the rape personifies the loss of her autonomy as a cost of marginalization. In Judith Butler's terms, the body becomes

the site of a political struggle where the absence of rights and recognition exposes the limits of agency.

Kimberlé Crenshaw, in her foundational work on intersectionality *Mapping the Margins* (1991), emphasizes how race, gender, class, and legal status intersect to produce unique forms of vulnerability that cannot be captured by gender alone. Crenshaw would likely argue that Zulema's experience, as a racialized, migrant, undocumented sex worker, cannot be fully understood through Butlerian gender performativity, because Butler's work, while foundational, has been critiqued for focusing too narrowly on gender and sexuality in isolation. "The intersectional experience is greater than the sum of racism and sexism, any analysis that does not take intersectionality into account cannot sufficiently address the particular manner in which Black women are subordinated" (Crenshaw, 1991, p.140). In the context of *Princesas*, this suggests that Zulema's trauma is not just about gendered violence, it is about structural xenophobia, racism, and immigration precarity, which multiply her vulnerability and shape the kinds of violence she suffers. Thus, her body is not only a site of gendered control, but also of national, racial, and legal domination.

The film presents several forms of bodily control and violence that particularly affect migrant sex workers. First is the violence of economic necessity that pushes women like Zulema into precarious work. The scene where Zulema sends money to her son in the Dominican Republic (*Princesas*, 2005, 00:40:25) illustrates how transnational motherhood imposes additional pressures on migrant women, who must sacrifice physical proximity to provide economic support. Second is institutional violence, embodied by the police officer who sexually exploits Zulema with false promises of documentation, representing how state power particularly targets undocumented women through their precarious legal status. Third, is social violence in the form of stigma, as shown when Caye's family remains ignorant of her

profession (*Princesas*, 2005, 00:28:15), illustrating how sex work is socially invisible even as it is economically necessary. Finally, there is the intimate violence of clients, demonstrated in the scenes where both women face sexual coercion and assault.

These layered forms of violence are not separate but interconnected manifestations of power operating through gender, race, nationality, and legal status. The film suggests that violence against sex workers is not exceptional but structural, embedded in the very social, legal, and economic systems that render certain bodies more vulnerable than others. As feminist scholar Julia O'Connell Davidson argues, the vulnerabilities of migrant sex workers stem not only from individual acts but from structural factors that constrain choice and agency (O'Connell, 2002, p. 87). *Princesas* effectively visualizes these structural constraints through the intimate portrayal of its protagonist's everyday experiences of violence and survival.

Fernando León de Aranoa's film offers a complex representation of sex work, immigration, and femininity in early 21st-century Spain. The stories of Caye and Zulema present multiple forms of oppression (gender, class, race, migration) and successfully illustrate how this affects the bodies and minds of marginalized women in society. As demonstrated throughout this essay, *Princesas* not only exposes the structural precariousness faced by sex workers but also reveals dualities: the relationship between gender and migration, the forms of violence that arise from these intersectionalities, the fetishism surrounding the female body, the desire for domination that arises from patriarchy and how this same system has pushed women to unite in a fight against inequality; a fight with varied perspectives, which has triggered debates among theorists. However, the representation of immigration and gender in *Princesas* is clear in its message and shows a profound understanding of how systematic inequality transcends the limits of simple stereotypes. In doing so, the film transcends mere storytelling,

offering a poignant critique of societal norms. It urges the audience to confront uncomfortable realities and consider how empathy and awareness may foster social change.

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